

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

Board split on \$10.25B budget

Some mayor-aligned members balk as plan sidesteps borrowing

By Kate Perez and Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

Despite the presentation of a balanced budget containing no loan for the upcoming Chicago Public Schools academic year after months of debates over a multimillion dollar budget deficit, the entirety of the Chicago Board of Education is not sold on the \$10.25 billion plan.

The proposal was the result of weeks of planning and bolstered by community engagement. It combines cuts to expenditures — that avoid cuts to classrooms — with input from outside partners such as the city and state, according to the district's Chief Budget Officer Mike Sitkowski, who presented the plan to the school board at their bimonthly meeting Wednesday.

Notably, it balances the budget without a \$200 million borrowing scenario or a \$175 million pension reimbursement to the city, as proposed by Mayor Brandon Johnson. Interim CPS CEO Macqueline King drew attention in recent days for pushing back on Johnson's proposals to rely on borrowing and make the pension payment.

King took over in June as the district was confronting a \$734 million budget crisis in the wake of leadership upheaval. Just days earlier, the former schools chief Pedro Martinez had left the district for a new job in Massachusetts after a protracted public disagreement with Johnson about how to balance last year's budget, which ultimately cost him his job.

The interim CEO stepped into the role with two immediate priorities: settling the budget and ensuring a smooth start to the school year.

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STUDENT SUES DISTRICT:

A Chicago Public Schools student accused the Board of Education in a lawsuit filed Tuesday of failing to run a "thorough" background check on a security guard who had been arrested several times and was later charged with sexually assaulting the girl. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

In DC, agents to patrol 24/7

Trump vows to increase presence of officers, suggests he will seek longer period of control

By Lindsay Whitehurst and Ashraf Khalil
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — As a wary Washington waited, the White House promised a ramp-up of National Guard troops and federal officers on the streets of the nation's capital around the clock starting Wednesday, days

after President Donald Trump's unprecedented announcement that his administration would take over the city's police department for at least a month.

The city's Democratic mayor walked a political tightrope, referring to the takeover as an "authoritarian push" at one point and later framing the infusion of officers as a boost to public safety, though

one with few specific barometers for success.

The Republican president has said crime in the city was at emergency levels that only such federal intervention could fix — even as District of Columbia leaders pointed to statistics showing violent crime at a 30-year low after a sharp rise two years ago.

For two days, small groups of federal officers have been visible in scattered areas of the city. That is about to change, the administration says.

A "significantly higher" presence of guard members was expected Wednesday night, and federal agents will be out 24/7 rather than largely at night, according to the White House. Hundreds of federal law enforcement and city police officers who patrolled the streets Tuesday night made 43 arrests, compared with about two dozen the night before.

In one neighborhood, officers

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STATE FAIR GOVERNOR'S DAY



Attendees cheer for U.S. House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries during the New York Democrat's keynote address on Governor's Day at the Illinois State Fair in Springfield on Wednesday. **DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

'Illinois is the blueprint'

Dems use gathering to celebrate Pritzker, others as leaders of resistance to Trump

By Rick Pearson, Jeremy Gornor and Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Democrats used their day at the State Fair on Wednesday to celebrate Illinois as a leader of the resistance to President Donald Trump, lashing out at the Republican administration and its allies in Congress in an effort to regain party momentum for next year's midterm elections. Setting the theme for the day

was the opening of the annual brunch of Democratic county chairs. The group featured a short AI-assisted video labeled, "Star Wars Episode II, the Orange Menace Returns" that portrayed Trump as Darth Vader and dressed various members of his Cabinet in Sith officer costumes while Illinois' Democratic members of Congress wore the clothing of Jedi fighters.

"This event is not just a fundraiser. It's a launching pad, because the next election is not

just another political contest," Kane County Democratic Chair Mark Guethle, who heads the statewide group, told nearly 2,000 people at the downtown Bank of Springfield Center. "It's a test of who we are as a nation. It's a test of whether we kick people off their health care so some wealthy corporations get a tax break."

A reelection-seeking Gov. JB Pritzker, who also is a potential 2028 White House contender, said Democrats nationally who are still lamenting last year's presidential

outcome should move forward and look to Illinois as an example.

"The pity party, the circular firing squad, the think-tank brainstorming sessions — they just need to be over. And what I'll say to those who are wondering what's next for the Democratic Party is this: She's alive and well and stronger than ever and right here living in the great state of Illinois," Pritzker said.

"There is a dark hopelessness

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DEXTER REED SHOOTING

Burke's office declines to file charges against CPD officers



Cook County State's Attorney Eileen O'Neill Burke announces Wednesday that her office declined to file charges against Chicago police officers who fatally shot Dexter Reed in 2024. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

By Madeline Buckley and Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

The Cook County state's attorney's office declined to file charges against Chicago police officers who fired dozens of shots at Dexter Reed in a shooting that roiled the city and drew scrutiny to police policies around traffic stops.

In a memo released Wednesday, the office found that the "evidence is insufficient to support criminal charges against these officers."

Dexter Reed, 26, was shot 13 times during a traffic stop shortly after 6 p.m. March 21, 2024, by Officers Thomas Spanos, Alexandra Giampapa, Victor Pacheco and Aubrey Webb, according to the memo. Reed, a former basketball player at Westinghouse College Prep high school, also shot Officer Gregory Saint Louis in the wrist.

An attorney for the officers did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

During a news conference announcing the decision, State's

Attorney Eileen O'Neill Burke said the "evidence is clear and overwhelming" that prosecutors would not be able to meet their burden of proof, calling the scene "terrifying and chaotic."

"What happened that evening was a tragedy. A young life ended. A police officer was shot with a potentially career-ending injury and many other lives were upended and an entire neighborhood was traumatized," she said.

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"What happened that evening was a tragedy. A young life ended. A police officer was shot with a potentially career-ending injury. ... This decision is not reached lightly nor does it diminish the tragedy that occurred."

— Cook County State's Attorney Eileen O'Neill Burke

